

THE GHARRIE

Position Before Direction: What a Land Rover in Angola can teach us about complexity, management innovation and executive judgement

There is a compelling story from the Angolan Bush War about a small Land Rover moving ahead of a much larger mechanised force. During Operation Protea in 1981, South African forces advancing through southern Angola included Ratel-based mechanised formations. The terrain around Xangongo presented a formidable challenge: flat, thick bush, soft sand, few reliable landmarks and limited visibility. In an account of the operation, a Land Rover is described as acting as a **trail-blazer** during the final approach to a SWAPO base. Its four-man crew moved ahead of the main force, with Bushmen scouts helping to identify a possible route, while a signaller communicated observations back to the command vehicle. The Ratels and the force behind could then move with a better understanding of what lay ahead.

The image is striking because the Land Rover was hardly the most powerful vehicle in the formation. Behind it was considerably greater organisational weight: armoured Ratels, infantry, communications, logistics and the command structure required to bring them together. Yet the small vehicle went first. Its purpose was not to win the battle. Its purpose was to **encounter the terrain before the main force committed itself to it**. It had to find a route, test the ground, interpret what it encountered and communicate what mattered to those following behind. The gharrie was therefore performing a function that was less visible than firepower but fundamental to its effective use. It was creating the conditions under which the larger force could move.

That distinction offers a useful metaphor for organisations operating in increasingly complex environments. The challenge facing executives is rarely a complete absence of information. In fact, organisations have more information, analytical capability and technological capacity than ever

before. The difficulty is that information does not necessarily produce understanding, and understanding does not necessarily produce sound judgement. When the environment is complex, the organisation cannot simply study the map more carefully and assume that the terrain will conform to it. At some point, someone has to move forward and discover what is actually there.

When the map stops working

The Angolan bush was difficult not simply because it was dangerous, but because it was difficult to interpret. A road with a known destination and predictable obstacles is a complicated problem: there may be many variables, but the relationships between them are sufficiently stable to allow planning and calculation. The Angolan bush presented something different. Thick vegetation, soft sand and limited landmarks meant that the environment itself influenced what could be seen, where vehicles could move and what information could be gathered. A route that looked viable from a distance might prove impassable when encountered directly. The map could provide an indication of where the force believed it was, but only engagement with the terrain could reveal whether that belief remained accurate.

This distinction is increasingly relevant to business. Executives are dealing with markets in which technology changes customer expectations, customer expectations alter competitive behaviour, competitors change investment patterns and those investments reshape the environment in which the organisation operates. Artificial intelligence is an obvious contemporary example: its significance is not simply that it introduces a new technology, but that it changes the relationships between people, processes, knowledge, costs, customers and competitors. The terrain is moving as the organisation moves through it.

In such circumstances, the traditional management instinct is often to produce a better map. More data is gathered, more scenarios are modelled, more dashboards are developed and more sophisticated strategic analyses are commissioned. These can all be valuable. But there comes a point where the organisation has to acknowledge that **the map is an interpretation of the terrain, not the terrain itself**. The gharrie provides a different response. Instead of attempting to eliminate uncertainty before moving, it creates a capability to move into uncertainty, learn from it and bring that learning back to the organisation.

The problem with organisational weight

There is an important paradox here. The more powerful an organisation becomes, the more expensive it can become to be wrong. A small team testing an assumption about a new customer proposition can discover that it is wrong at relatively little cost. A large organisation can make the same assumption, build a strategy around it, allocate capital, change structures, train thousands of employees and only then discover that the terrain has moved.

This is why I believe management innovation should be understood more broadly than the introduction of new technologies, structures or processes. At its deeper level, **management**

innovation is about changing how an organisation learns, senses and responds. It is about creating mechanisms through which the organisation can discover what it does not yet know before it commits its full weight.

The gharrie represents precisely such a capability. It is a form of forward sensemaking. It goes ahead of the organisational column, encounters reality at close range, tests assumptions and brings information back. The purpose is not to replace the main force, but to improve the quality of the decisions made by the main force. In contemporary organisations, the equivalent might be a small team exploring emerging customer behaviour, testing an AI application, challenging an established strategic assumption or entering a new market before the organisation commits significant resources.

The value of such activity is sometimes difficult to measure because its greatest contribution may be preventing the organisation from making an expensive mistake. Yet that is precisely why it matters. **Learning before commitment is a management capability.**

The terrain looks different through different lenses

This is where the gharrie connects directly with **Worldview LOA.** The people moving through the Angolan bush may be sharing the same physical environment, but they are not necessarily seeing the same thing. The driver is focused on what the vehicle can negotiate; the tracker is looking for spoor and disturbances in the landscape; the commander is considering the tactical implications; the signaller is concerned with what information needs to be transmitted to those behind. Their different responsibilities, experiences and positions influence what they notice and how they interpret what they see.

The same phenomenon occurs inside organisations. A CFO may look at declining margins and see the need for cost discipline, while an operations executive sees capacity constraints and the need for investment. A marketing executive may interpret changing customer behaviour as evidence that the proposition needs to change, while a technology executive sees an opportunity to redesign the underlying business model. They may all have access to much of the same information, yet arrive at different conclusions because they are appraising that information through different lenses.

This is the significance of the **Lens of Appraisal**. Our worldview does not merely influence the conclusions we reach after observing reality; it influences what we notice in the first place, what we regard as important and which explanations appear plausible. Consequently, executive disagreement is not always a contest between someone who has the facts and someone who does not. Sometimes it is the consequence of people standing in different places and therefore seeing different aspects of the same terrain.

The important question therefore becomes not simply, *"What do you think?"*, but **"From where are you looking?"** That question creates the possibility of a more sophisticated form of executive dialogue. Instead of immediately defending one's own interpretation, leaders can explore what the

other person is seeing, what their position enables them to see that others cannot, and which assumptions are producing their interpretation of the situation.

Position before direction

This brings us to the **Executive Sextant.** The metaphor is useful because a sextant is fundamentally concerned with establishing position. It does not determine where the navigator should go; it provides observations that help establish where the navigator actually is. That is precisely the discipline that is often missing from executive decision-making.

The natural executive question is, *"What should we do?"* But in complex environments, a more important question often precedes it: **"Where are we?"** What are we actually observing? What are we interpreting? Which assumptions are influencing our appraisal? What evidence would challenge our current position? What might another observer see from a different location? Until these questions have been considered, choosing a direction can create little more than confident movement.

The Executive Sextant therefore provides a way of thinking about executive judgement as navigation rather than prediction. Its logic moves from **observe, orient and appraise**, through **judge, engage and act.** The objective is not to create certainty where certainty is impossible. It is to establish a sufficiently reliable position from which a decision can be made, while retaining the capacity to adjust as new information emerges.

That is why **Position Before Direction** is more than a slogan. It is a principle of executive judgement. Direction only has meaning in relation to position. A strategy can be internally coherent and still be wrong because it was developed from an inaccurate understanding of where the organisation actually stands.

The gharrie and the Ratel

The relationship between the gharrie and the Ratel provides perhaps the strongest organisational lesson. The gharrie does not replace the Ratel, and the Ratel does not make the gharrie redundant. They perform complementary functions. The gharrie explores and senses; the Ratel carries organisational weight. The gharrie encounters uncertainty at close range; the Ratel converts understanding into coordinated action.

The challenge for modern organisations is to create that same relationship between **exploration and execution.** Too often, organisations commit their weight first and learn afterwards. They launch the transformation, implement the technology, restructure the business or invest the capital and only subsequently discover that their assumptions about the terrain were incomplete.

Management innovation offers an alternative. Create the organisational equivalent of the gharrie: a capability that can move ahead, explore, challenge, experiment and bring back insight before the larger organisation commits itself. Worldview LOA then helps executives understand why the

information coming back may be interpreted differently by different people, while the Executive Sextant provides a discipline for establishing position before deciding direction.

The real lesson

The gharrie's significance was never proportional to its size. Its value came from its **position**. It was ahead of the main force and therefore encountered the terrain before those behind it had to commit themselves to that terrain. It created knowledge through movement and allowed the larger force to act with a better understanding of what lay ahead.

That is a powerful metaphor for leadership in complexity. The answer to complexity is not necessarily more organisational power, more analysis or more certainty. Sometimes it is the ability to create a **forward edge of sensemaking:** people who can explore the emerging terrain, challenge established interpretations and bring back what the organisation needs to know before it commits its weight.

This changes the role of executive leadership. The executive does not need to have all the answers. The executive needs to create the conditions in which the organisation can discover better answers. That means making room for exploration, encouraging different perspectives, testing assumptions and ensuring that information from the organisational edge can influence decisions at the centre.

The gharrie reminds us that **forward movement and forward understanding are not the same thing**. An organisation can move quickly while operating from a flawed appraisal of its environment. It can execute brilliantly against a reality that has already changed. It can possess extraordinary resources and still lack an accurate sense of its position.

Good executive judgement therefore begins before the decision. It begins by understanding the terrain, recognising the lens through which it is being viewed and establishing the organisation's position before choosing its direction.

Position before direction.

The gharrie goes ahead to explore the terrain. **Worldview LOA helps us understand how we see it. Management innovation creates the capacity to explore what we do not yet know. The Executive Sextant helps us establish where we are. Executive judgement determines how we move from there.**

The quality of our direction depends on the accuracy of our position.